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A FREE GUIDE & WORKBOOK

Rebuilding After Divorce

Gentle, practical first steps for when everything has changed.

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A NOTE BEFORE YOU BEGIN

You don’t have to figure it all out today.



If you’re reading this, something big has ended, or is ending. Maybe the decision was yours, maybe it wasn’t. Either way, the life you knew is changing faster than you can keep up with.

I know this place not only as a therapist, but as a woman who has stood in it. When my own marriage ended, I had to use every tool I’d spent years teaching clients: steadying my body, letting myself grieve, slowing down big decisions, and slowly rediscovering who I was on my own.

What I learned is that rebuilding doesn’t start with a five-year plan. It starts with a few steady steps, taken one at a time.

This guide gives you those first steps. Each section has a short explanation and a simple worksheet. Print it, keep it by your bed or in your bag, and come back to it as often as you need. There’s no right order and no deadline.

Your best chapter isn’t behind you. It may be the one you’re about to write.

With warmth, Dr. Susan

How to use this guide

- **Go slowly.** One section a day, or one a week, is plenty.
- **Write things down.** Getting thoughts onto paper makes them easier to carry.
- **Be kind to yourself.** Hard days are part of rebuilding, not a step backward.

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STEP ONE

Steady your body first.

When life is upended, your nervous system treats it as a threat. Sleep gets lighter, appetite changes, and small decisions feel enormous.

Before you try to solve everything, give your body some stability. These habits won't fix the situation, but they give your mind enough calm to think clearly. Aim for "most days," not "every day."

My daily steadying checklist

- [ ] I went to bed and woke up at roughly the same times.
- [ ] I ate at least two simple, regular meals.
- [ ] I spent ten minutes or more outside, ideally walking.
- [ ] I talked with one person who makes me feel steady.
- [ ] I did one small thing just because I enjoy it.

When anxiety rises: the 4–6 breath

Breathe in through your nose for a count of **four**. Breathe out slowly through your mouth for a count of **six**. Repeat five to ten times. A longer out-breath signals your body that it is safe to settle.

Try it before difficult phone calls, before sleep, and any time your thoughts start racing.

Things that help me feel even a little calmer:

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STEP TWO

Make room for grief.

Even when divorce is the right decision, there is loss.

You may grieve the marriage, the family routines, the future you expected, or the version of yourself who lived that life. Grief often arrives mixed with anger, relief, guilt and fear, sometimes all in the same afternoon. That mix is normal. Pushing feelings away tends to make them last longer; giving them somewhere to go helps them move.

What I'm grieving

The relationship, routines, plans, roles, places, people...

What surprises me

Relief? Anger? Moments of lightness? All are allowed.

Journal prompts for hard evenings

- Right now I feel... and underneath that, I feel...
- What I miss most is... What I don't miss is...
- If my closest friend were going through this, I would tell her...
- One thing I handled today, even imperfectly, was...

A gentle reminder: anniversaries, holidays and first-times (the first birthday, the first school event alone) often bring a fresh wave. Plan something kind for yourself on those days rather than waiting to see how you feel.

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STEP THREE

Sort decisions into now, soon and later.

Divorce comes with a long list of decisions, and not all of them need to be made this month.

Major choices made in the first wave of shock are often the ones people later wish they had waited on. Giving yourself permission to wait is a form of self-protection. Write each decision on your mind into one of these three columns.

Now

Safety, housing for the next few months, essential bills, children's routines.

Soon

Legal and financial agreements, made with good professional advice.

Later

Where to live long-term, career changes, dating, big purchases.

Before any big decision, ask yourself:

- Does this need to be decided now, or does it only *feel* urgent?
- Am I choosing from fear, or from what I actually want?
- Who could I ask for advice: an attorney, mediator, financial professional, or trusted friend?
- How will I likely feel about this choice a year from now?

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STEP FOUR

Protect your peace with simple boundaries.

Boundaries aren't walls. They are clear, kind statements about what you will and won't do.

You don't owe anyone a long explanation. Short, calm sentences, repeated as often as needed, are usually the most effective. Here are some starting points to adapt in your own words.

> **WITH A FORMER SPOUSE**
> *"I'm happy to talk about the children's schedule. I'm not going to discuss our relationship. Let's keep to logistics."*

> **IF YOU'RE CO-PARENTING**
> *"Pickup is at 5 on Friday. Let me know by Wednesday if anything changes." Brief, polite, and focused on the children.*

> **WITH ADULT CHILDREN**
> *"I love you, and I'm not going to share the details of the divorce. You don't have to take sides."*

> **WITH WELL-MEANING FRIENDS & FAMILY**
> *"Thank you for caring. I'm not ready to talk about it today, but I'd love to get a walk together."*

A boundary I want to practice this week:

What I'll say, in my own words:

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STEP FIVE

Map your support.

Divorce can be isolating, especially when friendships were shared as a couple.

Different people help in different ways. Naming them makes it easier to reach out on a hard day, instead of waiting until you're overwhelmed. Asking for support is part of rebuilding, not a sign that you're failing at it.

Kind of support	Who could offer it
I can call them at 10pm	
They make me laugh	
Practical help (meals, rides, a handy friend)	
Professional guidance (attorney, financial, therapist)	
New connections I'd like to build	

Ideas for new connection

A walking group or fitness class · a book club · volunteering for a cause you care about · a divorce support group · reconnecting with an old friend you drifted from during the marriage.

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STEP SIX

Begin to answer “Who am I now?”

For years, your identity may have been tied to being a wife, a mother, or the one who held everything together.

You don’t have to answer this question all at once. Start small. Notice what you enjoy when no one else is choosing. Each choice you make for yourself adds to a clearer sense of who you are now.

Things I loved before the marriage

Things I set aside that I miss

Words that describe who I want to be in this next chapter

Circle any that resonate, or add your own.

Calm · Brave · Curious · Independent · Creative · Healthy · Connected · Playful · Generous · Grounded · Adventurous · Honest · Joyful · _____

My “small yes” list

Small, doable things I’ll say yes to this month, just for me: a class, a new recipe, a trip to the beach, rearranging a room.

PUTTING IT TOGETHER

Your first 30 days.

One focus per week. That's all.

Use this page to choose a single, realistic intention for each week. If a week doesn't go as planned, simply carry it forward. Progress after divorce is rarely a straight line.

Week	Suggested focus	My intention
Week 1	Steady: sleep, meals, a daily walk, the 4–6 breath.	
Week 2	Sort: fill in your Now / Soon / Later columns and handle one "Now."	
Week 3	Protect: practice one boundary and reach out to two people on your support map.	
Week 4	Rediscover: try one thing from your "small yes" list.	

At the end of 30 days, I noticed...

These steps reflect the first pillar of the REBUILD Method™, **Restore Your Foundation**: stabilizing daily life before working on the bigger questions of identity and what comes next.

WHEN TO REACH OUT FOR MORE SUPPORT

You don’t have to do this alone.

Self-help can carry you a long way, but sometimes it helps to have someone walk alongside you. Consider talking with a therapist if:

- Sleep, appetite or concentration haven’t improved after several weeks.
- Anxiety or sadness is making it hard to work, parent or take care of yourself.
- You feel stuck in the same painful thoughts or conflicts.
- You’re facing big decisions and want to make them from clarity rather than fear.
- You simply want a private, steady place to talk.

Let’s talk: a free 15–20 minute consultation

I work with women navigating divorce and midlife change, in person in Boca Raton and by secure video anywhere in Florida. We’ll talk about where you are, what you want to change, and whether we’re a good fit. No pressure, no obligation.

Schedule a free consultation

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